

The Mizzou Store Opportunity: Understanding Student Shopping Behaviors and Engagement Among 18–24-Year-Old Students

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1. Executive summary

The Mizzou Store faces a core challenge: students feel a strong emotional connection to the store, yet many do not consider it for practical purchases. Survey data reflects this gap directly: while store environment and design were rated highly (4.0 and 3.8 out of 5), perceived affordability lagged at just 2.66. This report examines the factors contributing to this phenomenon and proposes three strategic directions to address it.

The findings suggest that The Mizzou Store’s primary challenge is not a lack of student connection, but a communication gap between existing advantages and students’ purchasing considerations.

Price was a consistent concern, although it was not the only factor. Students actively compared prices across retailers, yet convenience and confidence in getting the correct materials often outweighed cost when items were needed quickly.

Peer influence also played an important role: students trusted classmates, friends, and campus channels such as GroupMe and Canvas more than conventional advertising, particularly for Mizzou apparel. At the same time, the store’s own social media visibility among students was extremely limited.

The study also identified a contrast between students’ positive attitudes toward the physical store, associated with school pride and campus identity, and their practical concerns about purchasing from it, including price assumptions and limited awareness of services such as rentals, AutoAccess, and TigerTech support.

Based on these findings, three strategic recommendations are proposed. First, for course materials, The Mizzou Store should make its functional value more visible by clearly communicating price comparisons, rental and digital options, AutoAccess savings, pickup convenience, and the benefits of official course materials. Student-focused bundles, loyalty

rewards, and limited-time promotions could further address price concerns without requiring broad price reductions. Second, the store should improve the online shopping experience by simplifying course material searches, displaying real-time inventory, and making format and price comparisons easier to understand. Third, for merchandise, the store should build symbolic value through student ambassadors, campus organizations, short-form content, and user-generated posts that show products and services in authentic student settings.

2. Secondary research

The Mizzou Store has asked how to close the gap between students' emotional connection and their practical purchasing behavior. The secondary research aimed to identify how communication processes shape students' awareness, evaluation, and purchase decisions by influencing perceived value, social influence, and digital engagement.

Previous studies suggest that students' shopping decisions are shaped by social influence and the sources they trust. Peer recommendations, subjective norms, and source credibility can affect Gen Z consumers' purchase intentions, especially when consumers discover products through digital and social channels (Huwaida et al., 2024; Siregar et al., 2023). This is relevant to The Mizzou Store because students may increasingly discover products and evaluate retailers through peer-based and digital channels before deciding where to shop. Students may be more likely to consider the store when its products, services, or value are communicated through credible campus sources, such as classmates, friends, student organizations, or university-related channels. Together, these studies suggest that communication within peer networks shapes not only purchasing decisions but also how students discover, interpret, and evaluate campus retail information.

Price remains an important concern, but students may evaluate value more broadly than the listed price of an item. The National Association of College Stores reported that campus stores accounted for 51% of purchased course materials in 2025, compared with 22% purchased from Amazon (National Association of College Stores, 2025). However, this national pattern does not necessarily indicate that students view campus stores as a better-value option. Instead, it may reflect institutional factors such as financial aid processing or required materials lists, a distinction worth noting. Even so, this suggests that campus stores can remain competitive by

emphasizing benefits such as correct course materials, immediate availability, customer support, and convenient pickup. The Mizzou Store already offers online course-material shopping, price comparison, and in-store pickup options (The Mizzou Store, n.d.-b). Its AutoAccess program also provides required digital materials through Canvas on the first day of class at a reduced cost (The Mizzou Store, n.d.-a). However, it is unclear whether Mizzou students know about these services or view them as competitive with Amazon, rentals, and other alternatives.

Online shopping experiences may also influence whether students consider or purchase from the store. Gen Z consumers often value speed, convenience, and a simple purchasing process (Lina et al., 2022). Research on social commerce further suggests that trust and credibility influence whether online engagement develops into purchase behavior (Putri et al., 2024). Although this research does not mean that TikTok or Instagram directly determines bookstore sales, it suggests that students may use social media and other digital channels to discover products, compare options, and form impressions of retailers. For The Mizzou Store, clear product information, reliable online ordering, accurate pricing, and a convenient transition from online browsing to store pickup may be important.

The physical store may offer benefits that online retailers cannot easily reproduce. Store atmosphere, including visual appeal and layout, can influence Gen Z consumers' willingness to visit a store (Jauza & Suryawardani, 2025). In addition, The Mizzou Store is connected to campus life and school identity through Mizzou apparel, gifts, supplies, and university-related merchandise. These products may create emotional value and encourage visits even when students do not need textbooks. At the same time, students increasingly use digital materials, rentals, free resources, or instructor-provided content instead of purchasing traditional printed textbooks (Mosia, 2024). Understanding students' relationships with The Mizzou Store therefore requires examining not only textbook purchases but also experiences with school supplies, technology, gifts, and Mizzou merchandise.

Overall, the secondary research suggests that students do not choose a campus bookstore for one single reason. Their decisions may reflect price expectations, perceived value, brand awareness, trust, peer influence, digital convenience, and in-store experience. However, the available research cannot show which of these factors matter most to current Mizzou students, whether

students are aware of The Mizzou Store’s existing services, or why they choose the store, Amazon, rental platforms, or other alternatives in particular situations. The survey was used to identify broader patterns in these factors, while the IDIs were used to provide more detailed explanations of students’ decision-making processes and the tradeoffs they make.

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Survey

Drawing on the themes identified in the secondary research, the survey examined how students’ purchasing channels, perceived value, social influence, and digital experiences shape their decisions to purchase from The Mizzou Store.

A convenience sampling method was used to collect responses from University of Missouri students. Although convenience sampling limits the generalizability of the findings, it was appropriate for an exploratory study of the target population. A total of 30 completed surveys were included in the analysis. Five incomplete responses were removed.

Category	Results
Gender	Female: 19; Male: 11
Academic level	Freshman: 4; Sophomore: 1; Junior: 11; Senior: 10; Graduate: 4
Living location	On-campus: 6; Off-campus in Columbia: 24

The survey included multiple question types. A 1–5 Likert scale was used to measure brand recognition, website experience, price perception, store environment, social influence, and shopping habits. Multiple-choice questions were used to collect information about shopping frequency, purchasing channels, budget, and social media usage. Demographic questions, including age, gender, year in school, major, and living location, were included to ensure respondents matched the target population and to identify differences among student groups. The survey was pretested with three students, and adjustments were made based on their feedback to improve clarity.

The results showed that textbooks were the largest purchase category, representing an average of 39.7% of purchases, followed by gifts (19.1%) and school supplies (18.1%). Students used both physical and online shopping channels, with 15 students mainly using physical stores, 10 using both physical and online channels, 2 mainly using online shopping, and the rest using neither. Brand recognition was moderate, with average scores of 3.3 for recognition, 3.7 for awareness, and 3.8 for logo recognition. However, bookstore social media engagement was limited, as 28 respondents reported no exposure to bookstore social media content.

Website experience received relatively low ratings, with overall usability averaging 2.9, while price perceptions were also moderate, especially affordability (2.66). In contrast, the store environment received stronger evaluations, including decoration (4.0) and overall design (3.8). These findings indicate that while students responded positively to the physical store environment, there may be a gap between students' perceptions of the store and their engagement with its digital channels.

3.2. In-Depth Interviews (IDIs)

The in-depth interviews were designed to complement the survey by exploring the motivations and thought processes behind students' purchasing decisions. Six semi-structured interviews were conducted with University of Missouri students selected from different majors and academic levels. The interview guide included one warm-up question followed by twelve questions covering purchasing behaviors, information sources, shopping experiences, brand perceptions, and future purchase intentions. A pilot interview informed minor adjustments to question clarity, and all interviewers followed the same guide and procedures to minimize interviewer bias.

The interviews added valuable context by revealing how students made purchasing decisions in situations that could not be fully explained through survey responses. One of the clearest patterns was that purchasing decisions were shaped by the balance between convenience and affordability rather than by price alone. Students described different decision-making strategies depending on how urgently they needed course materials. During busy weeks or before assignments, convenience became the priority. As one participant explained, "convenience usually wins when I'm busy," even if it meant spending more money. In less urgent situations, however, students

routinely compared prices across Amazon, Chegg, rental platforms, and the Mizzou Store before deciding where to purchase. These conversations suggest that students' decisions depended on their specific situations rather than following one consistent purchasing pattern.

The interviews also highlighted the importance of trust during the shopping process. Very few students mentioned advertisements when explaining how they decided what to buy. Instead, professors, Canvas announcements, classmates and friends were repeatedly described as the most reliable sources of information. One student recalled that a price comparison shared in a GroupMe chat immediately influenced the purchase because it clearly showed a less expensive option. Peer influence was equally important when purchasing Mizzou apparel. Participants explained that seeing friends wearing university merchandise felt more authentic than viewing products through official marketing. As one student commented, 'Seeing it on an actual person made it look better than just seeing it online or on a shelf.' These comments suggest that students often trusted personal experiences shared within their social networks more than promotional content.

One of the most meaningful insights was the contrast between students' emotional connection to the Mizzou Store and the way they evaluated it as a place to shop. Most interviews began with positive associations such as school spirit, campus traditions, or the university's black-and-gold identity. "The first thing I think of is school pride," one participant explained, while another described the Mizzou Store as something that "doesn't really feel like a normal bookstore." As the conversations continued, a different pattern emerged. Many students admitted they rarely compared textbook prices at the Mizzou Store because they assumed other retailers would be cheaper. Others were unaware of services such as textbook rentals, technology support, or price comparison options until they were mentioned during the interview. This suggests that students' expectations may discourage them from considering the Mizzou Store before they evaluate the available options. Improving awareness of existing services and communicating the bookstore's value more clearly may therefore have as much impact as changing prices themselves.

One challenge encountered during the interviews was that several participants no longer purchased many printed textbooks because instructors increasingly relied on digital platforms or online course materials. To address this issue, interviewers expanded follow-up questions to include digital resources and recent purchases related to the Mizzou Store. This adjustment also

highlighted an important shift in students' purchasing behaviors, suggesting that The Mizzou Store should increasingly be understood as a broader campus retail service rather than solely as a textbook provider.

4. Key Consumer Insights

Insight 1: Peers Shape Purchase Decisions

Students rarely rely on advertising alone when deciding what to buy. Instead, recommendations from friends, classmates, and other students play an important role throughout the purchasing process. This pattern was evident in the survey, where respondents strongly agreed that they would observe what other people buy before making similar purchases ($M = 4.27$) and ask friends for recommendations when they had little experience with a product ($M = 4.23$). They also reported frequently gathering information from friends or family before making purchasing decisions ($M = 3.90$). These findings are consistent with previous research suggesting that user-generated content and peer recommendations are perceived as more credible than traditional brand communication among Generation Z (Creator, 2026; Numerator, 2025). Likewise, Hapsari et al. (2024) argue that authenticity and trust significantly influence young consumers' purchase intentions, making peer influence especially powerful.

The interviews provided several examples of this behavior in practice. One participant explained, "I usually ask my friends before buying course materials," and described purchasing Mizzou hoodies after seeing a friend wearing one on Instagram. Another participant recalled that "someone in our GroupMe posted a screenshot comparing the rental price at Amazon and the Mizzou Store," which immediately influenced where many students rented their textbooks. Similar experiences appeared across multiple interviews, suggesting that students often trust classmates' experiences more than promotional messages from retailers. For the Mizzou Store, these findings indicate that student-generated communication may be particularly valuable because peer recommendations provide social validation that traditional promotional messages often lack. This means the store's communication budget is better spent activating peer networks than running conventional ads.

Insight 2: Students Construct Value Beyond Price

Students do not necessarily choose the lowest-priced option. Instead, they evaluate whether the benefits of convenience, reliability, and immediate access justify the cost.

The survey findings support this pattern. Respondents strongly agreed that they would purchase course materials from multiple retailers to obtain lower prices ($M = 4.03$), indicating that students actively compare alternatives. At the same time, The Mizzou Store's perceived affordability received a relatively low rating ($M = 2.66$), suggesting that many students enter the decision-making process with expectations that other retailers may provide better value.

The interviews further explained this tradeoff. Students described textbook purchasing as a balance between saving money and obtaining materials quickly and reliably. When they had sufficient time, they compared options such as Amazon, Chegg, rental platforms, and The Mizzou Store. However, convenience became more important when materials were needed immediately.

Students also indicated that they were willing to pay more when the value was tied to identity rather than function. One participant explained, "The first thing I think of is school pride. Every time I walk into the Mizzou Store, everything is black and gold, there are Tiger logos everywhere, and it just feels like Mizzou." This suggests that for apparel and merchandise, the relevant "value" is not convenience or price but authenticity and connection to university identity, which is a different calculation than the one students apply to textbooks.

Overall, The Mizzou Store's challenge is that students apply two distinct value calculations depending on the product category, and the store's current communication does not clearly address either one. Therefore, the strategic priority is not lowering prices but reshaping how students perceive value — practical for course materials, symbolic for merchandise.

Insight 3: Digital Communication Gaps Limit Student Engagement

The findings also suggest that the Mizzou Store has not effectively reached students through its digital marketing efforts. While most participants regularly searched online for products and compared prices, very few reported engaging with the bookstore's own digital channels. In the survey, 28 of the 30 respondents indicated that they had never seen content from the Mizzou Store on social media, suggesting extremely limited visibility among the target audience.

Previous research has shown that Generation Z expects brands to maintain active and engaging social media presences, with digital platforms serving as important sources of product discovery and brand interaction (Creator, 2026).

Interview responses further revealed opportunities for improvement beyond social media visibility. One participant said they had only recently learned that the bookstore offered textbook rentals, while another was unaware of TigerTech's technical support services until much later. Several students also identified problems with the website, including checkout failures, unavailable inventory that was only revealed during checkout, and uncertainty when comparing rental, digital, and printed textbook options. At the same time, students repeatedly mentioned discovering Mizzou apparel through Instagram posts shared by friends rather than through the bookstore itself. Together, these findings suggest that the issue is not students' willingness to engage online, but rather that the Mizzou Store's digital communication is not reaching them effectively. Increasing social media visibility, highlighting lesser-known services, and creating a smoother online shopping experience could improve awareness and encourage greater engagement with the bookstore.

5. Strategic Recommendations

Recommendation 1: Prioritize Value Communication Before Price Competition

For course materials, students evaluate the Mizzou Store based on functional value rather than price alone. Although convenience and reliability are important advantages, students still expect these benefits to be reflected in pricing that feels fair and worthwhile. This indicates that the bookstore should focus on increasing perceived value instead of competing solely through lower prices, particularly for course materials, where price is weighed against convenience and reliability rather than treated as the sole deciding factor.

Rather than competing primarily on price, The Mizzou Store should communicate its existing value proposition more clearly throughout the consumer decision journey. The bookstore could make clearer price-comparison tools that highlight differences among new, used, rental, and digital formats. Additional strategies could include semester starter bundles and loyalty rewards that reinforce the existing value of purchasing from The Mizzou Store.

Recommendation 2: Improve Digital Shopping Experience and Expand Online Services

The research indicates that students expect the same level of efficiency from the Mizzou Store's digital experience as they receive from other online retailers. While the bookstore offers several useful services, these resources are not always easy to find or use, limiting their value to students.

The bookstore should simplify its online shopping experience with students' purchasing habits in mind. Allowing students to search textbooks by course number, compare physical, rental, used, and digital versions on a single page, and view real-time inventory would make purchasing faster and less confusing. The website could also help students locate required course materials based on students' schedules and provide clearer information about services such as TigerTech, textbook rentals, and in-store pickup.

Recommendation 3: Build Symbolic Value Through Student-Centered Communication

For merchandise, where value is symbolic rather than functional, the bookstore has an opportunity to reach students more effectively through the platforms they already use every day. Instead of relying primarily on traditional promotional content, marketing efforts should better reflect students' interests, campus experiences, and purchasing behaviors, an approach that matters most for merchandise, where the deciding factor is authenticity and connection to campus identity rather than price. Rather than treating students only as audiences, The Mizzou Store should view students as communication partners whose everyday interactions strengthen credibility, visibility, and engagement across campus.

The store could design shareable price-comparison assets for channels students already use, such as GroupMe, rather than only official social accounts. Collaborating with student organizations, campus ambassadors, and content creators would help the bookstore reach students through authentic voices they already trust. User-generated content campaigns, seasonal giveaways, and interactive events could further encourage participation while increasing awareness of services that many students currently overlook. Consistently connecting online content with in-store experiences would also increase students' awareness of the bookstore's products and services.

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